

ITSP School Board Candidate Questionnaire

Please limit each response to approximately 200 words.

Candidate Name: Stephanie Anderson

1. Vision for Technology in Education

What role should technology play in K-12 education, and how should that role differ across elementary, middle, and high school grade levels?

I begin with gratitude and credit to the delegates I spoke with during the first half of the year, the conversations I have had with parents, students and educators and the work I've been able to do with ITSP for helping me articulate and hone my vision of technology in K-12 education.

My vision is that SPPS graduates are ready to join a world in which technology and Artificial Intelligence will significantly impact all aspects of their lives. To get here, preparation goes far beyond being able to use a particular type of technology or tool. SPPS students must grow skills in evaluation, critical thinking, experimentation, communication, justice, racism, ethics and more, and then have practice in applying what they learn to conversations and challenges around technology and AI. The path to this vision is realized over the student's entire K-12 educational career and will include differentiated access to technology. I appreciate the guidelines that the district has begun to set forth, and will work to refine and make them more specific and transparent, taking into account both the outreach I will continue to do in the community, as well as best practices and research in the field.

2. Student Devices and Classroom Learning

What is your perspective on the use of district-issued 1:1 devices (iPads) in Saint Paul Public Schools? What changes, if any, would you like to see in current practices (e.g., eliminate 1:1 devices for some or all grade levels, establish formal limits on screen time, move from iPads to Chromebooks, etc.)?

There are different factors to consider here. One is equity. Personally I don't love that my kids, especially my middle schooler, have their own SPPS-issued iPad. However, I have to recognize my positionality coming from a household where my children have access to our home computers and iPad, and this access is not something that all families in our district have. I think it is appropriate to encourage more paper-and-pencil activities for homework, but even with this, if students will need to do research or reference something online in order to complete that work, they will need to have a device.

I support current district policy to not allow students in elementary school to take home their iPads except under very specific circumstances. From my experience in my kids' classrooms when they were in elementary school and seeing iPads sitting on each table (even when they are not being used), I would, instead, like to see iPads stored and put away on a cart when not in use and handed out only for certain activities (and then collected after). I think this is a practice that could be implemented even in certain secondary levels / courses.

3. Attention, Engagement, and Student Well-Being

How should the district balance the educational benefits of technology with concerns related to student attention, engagement in learning, social development, mental health, and overall well-being?

A first step is to make sure that all stakeholders - not just district administration - are on the same page regarding what we know about this issue. Tasking just the district with determining a balance may leave out the voices of stakeholders in working out solutions that best fits each part of our school community.. If we want to make significant changes to the way we use technology in SPPS, and we want buy-in on those changes, we need to get as many stakeholders involved as possible (parents, students, families, educators, staff, school administration, labor, etc.). One idea I have is for the school board to direct the Superintendent to form a committee of stakeholders to learn about technology and student well-being. This committee should also be charged with making recommendations to the board as well as coming up with ways to disseminate their findings and recommendations to the larger SPPS and St. Paul communities. In general if we could eliminate some of the top-down approaches, we can get a clearer picture of where we are, where we want to be and how we can go about getting there.

4. Evidence and Learning Outcomes

What evidence or metrics would you want to see to determine whether classroom technology is improving student learning and educational outcomes and whether there is sufficient return on the district's investment?

Student outcomes are complex and the result of a myriad of factors, only some of which the school district has influence over. While there is research that points to a negative correlation between certain technology use and student outcomes, I would urge caution to those who may infer too strong of a causational relationship between the two (correlation doesn't equal causation!). We should consider educational research around, for example, student comprehension being greater when they physically write things down, as well as, to give another example, the ways in which technology can help educators differentiate instruction and get immediate realtime feedback on student performance.

In addition to the science, as a board member, I will be in continual conversation in the community, with families, students, educators and administrators to hear about their experiences - their struggles and successes - and perspectives around technology in education.

5. Family and Community Engagement

What role should parents, families, students, and educators play in shaping district technology policies and practices?

Some St. Paul families choose to not send their children to SPPS because of what they know about (or in some cases, what they perceive to be) technology use in the district. I've spoken with families who have left SPPS in part because of their dismay over screentime in the classroom, and still others who seem to be on the verge of leaving SPPS if they don't see serious change to the district's technology policy. As a district that (not uniquely) struggles with enrollment, we have to take all of this very seriously.

Hats off to ITSP and the outreach work you've done with stakeholders (parents, families, educators) and district administration. You all are highly informed on the benefits, challenges and dangers around technology in schools and have established your group as a significant player in technology

discussions. As a board member, I want to continue to be in conversation with ITSP as I decide how to move forward in engaging more stakeholders in our community and would recommend - again with the guidance of ITSP - that, in formal discussions around technology in schools, ITSP representatives have a seat and voice at the table.

6. Accountability and Oversight

As a School Board member, how would you evaluate progress on technology-related goals and hold district leadership accountable for implementation, budget, and outcomes?

I support the board's BIGG goals around technology and AI, as well as the requirements placed on district administration to report on and achieve those goals. I would also like to be more aggressive on these goals, including the timeline given to district administration to deliver on them. I would also refine the current BIGG goal around AI (discussed more below). As I've mentioned throughout, I will continue to be in community, at ITSP meetings, talking with stakeholders and going into schools to learn about and see how we are implementing technology-related goals. I will continue to inform myself on best practices and research. Technology and AI are changing at alarming speeds and so I will maintain all these relationships and avenues of communication and learning in order to be able to be flexible and timely respond to new information and concerns, making adjustments to our goals when necessary.

7. Artificial Intelligence

As artificial intelligence and other emerging technologies become increasingly available to students and educators, what principles should guide district decisions about their use? Do you support a moratorium on generative AI in Saint Paul Public Schools while the district undertakes a full review?

Regarding AI in schools I sit with two truths: first, students who graduate from high school will enter a world where AI plays a significant role. Second: AI is exploding at alarming, and essentially unregulated, rates. Recently *The New Yorker* reported on three main arguments against the use of generative A.I. in children's education. In summary, these deal with the cognitive offloading when using AI, the danger of chatbots that mimic emotional intimacy, and how AI privileges the most efficient route to an answer over encouraging students to "get messy" with the learning process. As an educator with more than 20 years of experience, these arguments resonate with me and how I have seen students evolve alongside the evolution of AI.

I support a moratorium on generative AI in SPPS while the district undertakes a full review. I appreciate the work that the board has been doing around AI, including a recently-created BIGG goal, and would modify that goal to call for this review and moratorium. I also would call for discussion with our educators about what support they would need in order to feel like they can confidently and effectively use and teach with AI.

8. Looking Ahead

If elected, what would be your highest priority related to technology use in Saint Paul Public Schools during your first term?

I commit to staying abreast of both the body of literature around best practices as well as movements across our country to limit or even eliminate technology in our schools. I envision that our colleagues in Los Angeles Unified could be great partners to connect with and learn alongside; reaching out to LAUSD would be one of my first steps in directing technology policy.

Secondly, as I've mentioned above, we need a clear picture of how technology is being used in our schools and so I would direct the Superintendent to conduct a technology survey. I would request all information regarding the cost to the district for the technology that we use (hardware and software). I want usage data on each application, including YouTube and the internet. If there is an application for whose usage the district is unable to track, then the application should not be in the suite available to SPPS users. I also think that the board should direct the creation and execution of a survey to all educators regarding both the ways they use technology, their vision for how technology should best be used in the classroom and what they would need to achieve that vision.

Thank you for your participation. Please return to intentionaltechnologysaintpaul@gmail.com by September 25, 2026.